

Dink Volleys

1. Lesson Recap

The dink volley is taking your opponent's dink out of the air at the kitchen line, before it bounces. Instead of waiting for the soft shot to land, you reach forward and meet it with a controlled, blocking motion.

The dink volley keeps pressure on your opponents and steals time away from them. Because you contact the ball earlier, they have less time to recover and reset. A good dink volley stays soft and low, lands back in the kitchen, and keeps you in control of the net.

Remember the rule: you can take a dink out of the air, but you cannot have any part of your body touching the kitchen when you do. Your feet must stay behind the non-volley zone line.

2. Big Idea

The dink volley is about taking time away from your opponent, not hitting a winner.

Think: "soft block, out front, stay behind the line." Your job is to absorb the ball with a steady paddle and place it back low, so your opponents stay stuck on defense.

3. Key Cues

- "Catch it, don't swing."
- "Soft hands, loose grip."
- "Paddle out in front."
- "Steady paddle, let the ball come."
- "Feet behind the line."
- "Move my feet, not just my arm."
- "Block it back low."
- "Stay tall, lean from the hips."
- "Only take the easy ones out of the air."
- "Reset to ready after every ball."

4. Step-by-Step

1. Set up at the kitchen line in an athletic ready position, paddle up and out in front of your body.
2. Keep a relaxed grip, around a 3 or 4 out of 10, so your hands can stay soft.
3. Watch the ball off your opponent's paddle and decide early whether it is comfortable to take out of the air.
4. If it is, keep your paddle out in front and bring it to the ball instead of reaching or stabbing at it.
5. Use a small, quiet motion. Let the ball come to a still paddle and gently absorb it.
6. Contact the ball in front of your body, with the paddle face slightly open to lift it softly.
7. Guide the ball back low into the kitchen. Aim for a soft landing, not power.
8. Keep your feet behind the non-volley zone line. Lean forward from the hips if you need a little more reach.
9. Recover your paddle back to the ready position immediately after contact.
10. If the dink is too low or too far away, let it bounce instead and play a normal dink.

5. Common Mistakes

- Swinging at the ball: A dink volley is a block, not a swing. A big motion sends the ball too hard or pops it up. Keep the paddle quiet and let the ball do the work.
- Reaching and stabbing: Stretching the arm out to poke at the ball causes pop-ups and lost balance. Move your feet to get into position and keep the paddle in front of your body.
- Gripping too tightly: A tight grip makes the ball spring off the paddle. Loosen your grip so your hands can absorb the ball.
- Stepping into the kitchen: Touching the non-volley zone while volleying is a fault. Keep your feet behind the line and lean from the hips instead.
- Taking every ball out of the air: Trying to volley dinks that are too low or wide leads to errors. Take the easy ones and let the tough ones bounce.
- Forgetting to reset: Dropping the paddle after contact leaves you unprepared for the next ball. Return to ready right away.

6. Self-Check

- Am I keeping my paddle out in front of my body?
- Am I blocking the ball instead of swinging at it?
- Are my hands relaxed and soft?
- Did I move my feet to get into position?
- Were my feet behind the kitchen line when I made contact?
- Did the ball stay low and land back in the kitchen?
- Did I only take comfortable balls out of the air?
- Did I reset to ready position after the shot?

7. Homework

Practice these before your next play session:

- Wall block drill: Stand a few feet from a wall in your ready position. Gently volley the ball against the wall 30 times with a soft, quiet paddle. Focus on a still paddle and a loose grip, not power.
- Soft-hands catch drill: Have a partner toss balls toward you at the kitchen line. Instead of hitting, "catch" each toss on your paddle face by absorbing it so it barely bounces off. Do 20 reps to build feel.
- Partner dink volley drill: Dink back and forth with a partner. When you get a comfortable ball above net height, take it out of the air and block it back low. Do this for 5 minutes, keeping every ball soft.
- Footwork reset drill: At the kitchen line, take a dink volley, then practice quickly recovering your paddle and feet to ready position. Do 15 reps focusing on balance and staying behind the line.
- Choice drill: With a partner feeding mixed dinks, decide on each ball whether to volley it or let it bounce. Do 20 reps to train good judgment about which balls to take.
- Game awareness task: During recreational play, notice how often taking a dink out of the air rushes your opponent compared to letting it bounce.

8. Game Application 🎮

Use the dink volley when you are settled at the kitchen line and your opponent gives you a dink that is comfortable to reach, usually around waist height or higher. Taking it out of the air shortens their recovery time and keeps them on defense.

Do not force it. If the dink is low, dropping fast, or pulling you off the court, let it bounce and play a normal dink instead. Forcing a tough volley usually gives away a free point.

In doubles, the dink volley is a patience tool, not a finishing shot. Use it to keep pressure on and wait for your opponents to pop a ball up. When they finally give you a high, attackable ball, that is your chance to speed it up. Until then, block softly, stay behind the line, and stay ready with your partner.

9. Visualization 👁️

Before you play, picture yourself standing at the kitchen line, balanced and relaxed, paddle up and out in front of you. You feel calm and patient, ready for a soft exchange.

Now imagine your opponent's dink floating toward you at a comfortable height. You keep your paddle still, move your feet slightly into position, and let the ball meet your soft paddle face. The ball settles and drops gently back into the kitchen, low and unattackable. Your feet stay behind the line, you reset your paddle, and you feel in complete control of the point.

10. Quick Reminders 🏓

- Soft hands, loose grip.
- Block it, don't swing.
- Paddle out in front.
- Feet behind the kitchen line.
- Take only the comfortable ones out of the air.
- Keep it low and back in the kitchen.
- Reset to ready after every shot.
- Be patient and wait for the pop-up.

11. Resources

Use these resources for optional review away from the court. The lesson notes above are your main practice plan.

Articles

- [Mastering The Pickleball Dink: Strategy At The Kitchen Line](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
A clear overview of dinking strategy at the kitchen, including when to keep the ball low and unattackable and how that pressure forces opponents into mistakes.
- [How to Perfect Your Volley Dink](#)
Source: Selkirk Sport
Strategic insights focused specifically on the volley dink, including why taking the ball out of the air takes time away from your opponent.
- [How to Hit a Dink Shot in Pickleball](#)
Source: The Art of Pickleball
Breaks dinking down to getting low, setting the paddle, and pushing from the shoulder, and explains how to handle balls taken out of the air with a dink.

YouTube Videos

- [How To Take Dinks Out Of The Air | An easy way to learn and master the volley dink](#)
Channel: PrimeTime Pickleball
A beginner-friendly, step-by-step guide to the volley dink, with simple tips on grip pressure, a stable paddle, and watching the ball.
- [The Secret to Dink Volleys from a Pro | Level Up Kitchen Game](#)
Channel: John Cincola Pickleball
Explains the common mistake of pushing the paddle out and adding power, and how a still paddle at full extension gives you control and stops pop-ups.
- [Drastically Improve Your Pickleball Game With This One Simple Shot: The Volley Dink](#)
Channel: Ryan Murphy Show
Covers grip, paddle position, footwork, and timing for the volley dink, plus how to decide which balls to take out of the air and which to let bounce.

Rules and Strategy References

- [USA Pickleball Rules Summary](#)
Review the non-volley zone rules. They explain why you must keep your feet behind the kitchen line whenever you take a dink out of the air.
- [Complete Pickleball Rules Guide](#)
A broader rules overview that connects the kitchen, volleying, and court positioning, so you understand when a dink volley is legal and when it becomes a fault.